

Episode 179: *Mawaru Penguindrum* Colour Design Notes – Part 6

This month I've been interviewed in various places about *Mawaru Penguindrum* and *Saint Seiya*, doing interviews several times. Well, I apparently have a basically talkative disposition, so I end up speaking enthusiastically with abundant service spirit. Good grief (laugh).

When I was younger I was trying to be cool and reserved, wanting to show my character and such, but lately I don't think about such things (laugh). Now it's like a stance of "if everyone's happy, I'll do whatever I can" (laugh).

Well, this column has become like that too (laugh).

Though I'm often delayed due to being pressed by busyness, I'm thinking of working hard to write vigorously.

Now then.

Episode 4: The Falling Princess Storyboard & Direction/Kaneko Shingo (金子伸吾), Colour Direction/Tsujita Kunio

Ringo continues stalking, and today she's invited by Tabuki to go bird watching in the park. Shoma follows along. But with the appearance of a skunk and crows devouring their lunch, Ringo becomes frustrated that she can't create the developments written in her diary. Is this the Penguindrum? Shoma steals a look at such a diary. Then Tokikago Yuri (時籠ゆり) appears. Learning that Yuri is Tabuki's fiancée, heartbroken Ringo takes the final measure and goes into the pond. It was Shoma who saved the drowning Ringo, but Ringo thinks she was able to kiss Tabuki as desired. Meanwhile, at Akasaka-mitsuke Station, Kuho Asami (九宝阿佐美) was pushed down an escalator by someone. Such was Episode 4.

The general flow of production meetings for *Mawaru Penguindrum* was like this: First the script would come up and storyboard work would begin. Through one-on-one "storyboard camps" between the storyboard person and Director Ikuhara, the storyboard would be completed. After storyboard completion, immediately following would be the "direction meeting." Here, centered on Director Ikuhara with that episode's directing staff, Chief Director Nakamura Akiko, Assistant Director Yamazaki Mitsue, and myself (with animation director and photography director participating as needed), we would confirm scene by scene what kind of screen to make, or whether the storyboard showed this kind of performance but was this really okay? - confirming methods and such. There was always active opinion exchange here, and each episode's policy was decided almost entirely in this meeting. In this meeting we'd decide which scenes needed art board orders, determine cuts to prioritise for layout submission, and sometimes additional character settings would be ordered.

After this "direction meeting," individual animation meetings with the key animators. Then when priority layouts came up, "art board meetings." Art directors Akiyama and Nakamura Chieko, the episode's directing staff, Yamazaki, Akiko, and myself. Here we'd order art boards. We'd also meet about art settings for future episodes. Then about a week later, "art meetings." Meetings about the actual art for individual scenes and cuts of the story. The episode's directing staff, Yamazaki, Akiko, the two art directors and assigned art staff, and myself and that episode's assigned colour director.

When art boards came up, everyone including the director would check them. When boards got OK, I'd place characters on them to design scene-by-scene colouring, get OK from the directing staff, Yamazaki, and Akiko, then I'd write the colour direction schedule, and based on that have "colour direction meetings" with the colour director. And after that, "photography meetings." Photography director (from Episode 7 onward, 3D and special effects staff also participated), episode directing staff, Yamazaki, Akiko, and myself participated.

Having completed all these meetings, rushes would come up, then editing, voice recording... and so on.

I participated in meetings across the broad range from storyboard completion to photography meetings like this. I was allowed to participate quite actively in screen creation by expressing opinions. I don't actually know very well how other colour designers work, but generally my area of responsibility this time was "overall screen." By participating from the earliest processes as much as possible, I could see the whole picture even more, and many of my ideas were reflected.

So, Episode 4.

"That fluttering thing they did in that *Patlabor* short *Mini-Pat* - something like that," said Director Kaneko. This was during the direction meeting. Those fluttering puppet shows where you draw front and back pictures on paper, attach them to chopsticks, and move them by hand under the stage. We were going to do something like that in the main story during Ringo's fantasy scene. The storyboard was already drawn that way. Of course, without the chopsticks, but the animation would be like so-called "gen-satsu" (shooting only rough animation), putting white borders around characters to create a "drawn on paper feel," and having photography move it fluttering and spinning without using in-betweens. We decided to add drop shadows on the background to create a cheap stage-like feel. This would be easy for animation and colouring, but photography would definitely be tough. So I think we had photography director Oyama for Episode 4 participate in this direction meeting to get his opinion. Oyama hesitated for a moment but said "Well, I'll try!"

This seemed like it would create quite an atmosphere, but the problem was the background. What to do with the art? We thought it would be better if it had a different atmosphere from normal background space. To make it look puppet show-like and stage-like, we consulted with the art team. We had the background drawn with a stage backdrop-style feel in mind, and additionally had paper-like texture added to the backgrounds. This differentiated it from normal background space. But we still wanted one more something, so we decided to add a "frame" to the entire fantasy scene. Akiko designed and drew this, and I coloured it for the final decision.

Thus, the world of "Ringo's fantasy scene" was completed with white-bordered fluttering animation + backdrop-style background art + drop shadow photography processing and movement + frame. There was just one problem. This fantasy scene starts from inside a subway car. This subway was entirely assembled in 3D, so it didn't seem like we'd have much freedom. But if we made all the subway backgrounds for the fantasy scene hand-drawn, it would be a bit too different. The subway should maintain that precise 3D feel, said Director Ikuhara. So then, for now, shall we change the car interior colour - including the outlines of the 3DBG (we conveniently call 3D modelled backgrounds this) - and change the colour completely? I tried changing it to pink outlines and an overall pink tone, but hmm, it was somehow unsatisfactory. It didn't look very changed. So I consulted with the art team, and they created a sample with floral pattern texture applied to the car's walls and floor. "Oh! That might work!" and everyone immediately gave it the OK. When I checked with photography they said "We can probably manage it somehow," and that "floral fantasy subway" was born.

However, this caused trouble later. Actually, that floral subway took an incredible amount of rendering time during photography. We had imagined this to some extent, but it took far longer than we'd imagined, so we had to extend the master schedule. But fortunately it was still May before broadcast began, so we managed, and among us it secretly became "subways require caution!" Looking back now, I'm really glad this wasn't during the difficult later period (laugh). Well, subway aside, I hadn't even imagined at this time that this fluttering direction would power up even further and appear again (laugh).

Even so, that skunk with the "KIGA" pattern. Why the "KIGA" pattern? Even I don't know the reason (laugh). It was quite a mysterious existence, but the name "Kiyoshi-kun" apparently comes from the name of animator Hasegawa Shinya's pet cat (laugh).

(12.02.23)